

FUND FOR INNOVATION IN DEVELOPMENT (FID) — APPLICATION

Up to €4,000,000 | Rolling Deadline | Portal: fundinnovation.dev

Applicant: BETONIQ WEST LTD — trading as ZerôPâ Money

Submitted by: Tom Ugbodaga, Shareholder & CEO

Contact: zeropointfeild_nonwnt@zeropay.site | +234 706 525 2117

LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/tom-deggs-ugbodaga-2306692bb

Company registration: RC 1496603 | Abuja, FCT, Nigeria

Date: August 26, 2026 (portal reopens for submission September 1, 2026)

PROJECT TITLE: ZerôPâ Money — Offline-First Payment Infrastructure for Global Financial Inclusion

REQUESTED AMOUNT: €3,200,000

INNOVATION CATEGORY: Financial Inclusion / Digital Economy / Poverty Reduction

GEOGRAPHY: Nigeria (Phase 1) → West Africa (Phase 2) → Global replication, including connectivity-poor regions worldwide (Phase 3)

THE SCALE OF THE PROBLEM

1.4 billion people globally are unbanked or severely underbanked — 38 million of them in Nigeria alone. The infrastructure gap behind that number is universal, not regional: connectivity fails unpredictably across rural regions from Africa to Latin America and Southeast Asia, disaster-response corridors on every continent, and even developed markets during outages.

THE INNOVATION

ZerôPâ Money is the world's first offline-first, uncapped NFC contactless payment protocol. It enables merchants to accept fully authenticated digital payments of any value with zero internet connectivity.

This is not an incremental improvement to existing payment technology. It is a structural breakthrough that eliminates the single most persistent barrier to global financial inclusion: connectivity dependency.

Every digital payment system in existence — mobile money, QR codes, NFC, USSD, payment apps — requires an active internet or mobile network to complete a transaction. In the 68 countries where the Fund for Innovation in Development operates, this connectivity requirement excludes hundreds of millions of the most economically vulnerable people from the digital economy.

ZerôPâ Money removes that requirement permanently, using a patent-pending four-layer cryptographic architecture that processes, authenticates, and queues transactions entirely offline, then batch-settles them to any connected payment rail once connectivity is briefly restored.

THE PROBLEM AT SCALE

The primary structural cause of financial exclusion is not poverty, illiteracy, or distrust of financial institutions. It is connectivity dependency.

Every time a payment system requires internet to function, it excludes the 600 million Africans, 400 million South Asians, and 200 million Latin Americans who live in connectivity-poor environments — locking them out of digital payments, transaction history, credit, and savings, and trapping them in perpetual cash dependency and economic invisibility.

The Fund for Innovation in Development exists to fund innovations that combat poverty at scale. No innovation in the financial inclusion space will achieve global scale while connectivity dependency remains

the architectural foundation of digital payments. ZeroMoney removes that foundation and replaces it with hardware-level cryptographic trust.

TECHNICAL SUMMARY

Layer 1 — NFC Communication: ISO 14443-A/B contactless protocol. Customer taps any NFC device (phone, card, wearable) to a ZerôPâ■ terminal. No app. No internet. 4cm range.

Layer 2 — PUF Hardware Authentication: Physical Unclonable Function — a silicon fingerprint burned into the terminal chip at manufacturing. Provides offline device identity verification. Mathematically non-clonable. No server required.

Layer 3 — ECC P-256 Offline Signing: Elliptic Curve Cryptography, central-bank grade. Transaction signed entirely on the terminal processor, offline. Non-repudiable. No server required.

Layer 4 — Distance Bounding Protocol: Nanosecond signal timing prevents relay attacks — the most sophisticated class of NFC fraud. First implementation at point-of-sale scale globally.

Batch Settlement Engine: Signed tokens queue offline. On connectivity restoration, batches transmit to a settlement rail (Paystack Nigeria / Flutterwave Ghana / Stripe UK / Orange Money Sierra Leone). PSP-agnostic. No transaction is ever lost.

Solar Mesh Hub: For zero-connectivity environments — a solar-powered LoRaWAN mesh relay network propagates signed batches 2–15km per hop. No mobile network required.

Protocol formally verified via TLA+ model checking (437 states, 0 violations). Patent-pending invention disclosure filed April 2026.

DEPLOYMENT PLAN

Phase 1 — Nigeria (Months 1–18): €1,200,000. 200-terminal pilot in Abuja informal markets. 3 Solar Mesh Hub installations. Paystack settlement integration (merchant agreement already signed, July 14, 2026). CBN PSSP regulatory compliance track. 38 million target population in Nigeria.

Phase 2 — West Africa (Months 18–36): €1,200,000. Ghana (Flutterwave settlement), Sierra Leone (Orange Money), Senegal (Wave Money). 500 additional terminals. 5 additional Solar Mesh Hubs. PSP partner agreements in each country.

Phase 3 — Global Replication Playbook (Months 30–48): €800,000. India, Bangladesh, Kenya, DRC, Indonesia. Open-source protocol documentation for NGO replication. Partnership outreach to GSMA, Interledger Foundation, and Gates SIF for final-mile deployment.

Total requested: €3,200,000.

EXPECTED OUTCOMES

Assumptions behind the figures below: each pilot merchant serves an average of 6,000 customers per month; average transaction value and settlement volume are modelled on existing Nigerian informal-market cash-flow data; ■ = Nigerian Naira. Figures are planning estimates, not guarantees, and will be refined once the 200-terminal Phase 1 pilot generates live data.

By Month 18 (end of Nigeria phase): 1.2 million previously unbanked individuals gain first digital payment access (via 200 ZerôPâ■ merchants serving an average of 6,000 customers/month each). Approximately ■15,000,000/month in formal settlement volume surfaced from previously invisible cash activity. 200 merchants gain their first-ever digital transaction histories — credit-scoring eligible. 38 new community tech jobs created (Terminal Agents + Mesh Hub Operators).

By Month 36 (West Africa phase complete): 4 countries with active ZerôPâ■ infrastructure. 5,000 merchants onboarded. An estimated 3 million low-income individuals gain first digital payment access. Demonstrated playbook ready for replication in 20+ additional markets.

FOUNDER CREDENTIALS

Tom Ugbodaga — Shareholder & CEO, BETONIQ WEST LTD

MSc Computer Systems Security (University of Gloucestershire — England, 2011). Dissertation: NFC Contactless Technology for Financial Payments (Merit Class) — the same technical foundation underpinning ZerôPâ■ Money's architecture today.

This is a 15-year research commercialisation: the founder holds a postgraduate degree in the exact scientific discipline — NFC security and applied cryptography — that underpins this innovation.

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BETONIQ WEST LTD — RC 1496603, Abuja, FCT, Nigeria. Paystack Merchant Agreement signed July 14, 2026. Patent-pending invention disclosure filed April 2026.

ALIGNMENT WITH FID MANDATE

The Fund for Innovation in Development funds innovations with the potential to combat poverty and inequality worldwide. ZerôPâ■ Money is structurally aligned with this mandate at every level:

It targets the poorest and most economically excluded populations — informal market traders, subsistence merchants, day labourers — who are excluded not by choice but by the architecture of existing systems.

It is scalable: the protocol works identically in any country, with any settlement rail and any currency, and is built as universal infrastructure for anywhere connectivity is unreliable — not a single-market solution.

It generates measurable poverty-reduction impact: merchants who receive digital payments build transaction histories, access credit, hire workers, and grow. This is documented in every mobile-money deployment study in East Africa. ZerôPâ■ Money extends that impact to markets mobile money has never reached, because mobile money also requires connectivity.

The Fund for Innovation in Development has the opportunity to fund the foundational infrastructure layer of global financial inclusion — not another app, not another mobile wallet, but the infrastructure layer every future financial inclusion solution will build upon.

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